

BOUNDARY-SPANNING FUNCTIONS SERVED BY RURAL SCHOOL PSYCHOLOGISTS

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Summary: The impact of perceived environmental demands on the roles and job satisfaction of the school psychologist in rural school systems was explored. Superintendents rated their perceptions of the community context and the psychologist's involvement in interagency linking functions. School psychologists rated their performance of boundary-spanning functions and their job perceptions. Results indicated that certain perceived environmental pressures are related to the performance of boundary-spanning activities. Those who performed boundary-spanning functions are more satisfied with their jobs and more influential in determining their roles.

Although authors concerned with characterizing the role and functions of school psychologists have touched on their increasing involvement in community-related services, the performance of professional activities outside of the educational system has never been systematically explored. Previous efforts to describe the functions performed by the school psychologist have focused primarily on direct clinical or consultation services (Meacham & Peckham, 1978; Ramage, 1979). Recognizing that such broad distinctions might obscure important differences in the practice of school psychology in urban versus rural areas, Hughes & Clark (1981) found that the rural practitioner's role was more diverse than his or her urban counterpart, less oriented toward assessment-related activities, and more oriented toward system-wide and community-related issues. The school psychologist's role vis-à-vis the community has been discussed by others who encourage coordination of efforts, communication of information regarding needs and services, and the initiation of community involvement (Brantley, Reilly, Beach, Cody, Fields, & Lee, 1974; Plas, 1981; Reilly, 1969; Sepez, 1972). Although closer relationships between local mental health programs and school psychological services have been advocated (Fine & Epstein, 1969), they may also be problematic, and specific interventions have been suggested to remedy problems of professional competition, overlapping functions, and differing role expectations (Steinberg & Chandler, 1976). Thus, there are potential costs as well as benefits to performing community-related functions.

Consideration of the factors associated with this expansion of the school psychologist's role is important for two reasons. Role definition, specifically the limited autonomy school psychologists enjoy and the lack of support they receive from teachers, administrators, and the public (Meyers, Brown, & Coulter, 1982), was one of the primary professional issues identified at the Olympia Conference. One of the general solutions discussed was enhanced visibility outside of the school system as well as more role flexibility within it. A second professional issue that has surfaced recently is a concern for high levels of stress, dissatisfaction, and turnover among school psychologists that have been viewed as direct results of too limited role definition, high